Reach

# *Third-party mentions* get brands *named* in AI answers. *Unbranded links* don't.

## How external pages get brands named in AI answers. AI SEO study across 94,249 AI answers

94,249 brand-answer pairs, repeated samples of tracked prompts

4 engines · 43 brands, mostly B2B · Jan 1 - Aug 21, 2026

Unbranded link: 2.0% named · no mention: 1.4%

Mention, no link: 27.9% · 3+ pages naming you: 63.8%

Same brand: 3+ pages beat 1 page in 15 of 15 brands

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, n = 94,249 brand-answer pairs



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# What we *studied*

Among pages AI already cites, what makes the answer say your name?

## 1 Cited is not the same as named

AI can cite a page and still not say your brand. We look only at pages AI cites, not at how pages get cited.

## 2 Mention vs unbranded link

Mention: your brand name is in the page text. Unbranded link: the page links to your site but never says your name.

## 3 Named = the answer says your brand

Reach's extraction flag. Brand-answer pairs sampled every 2nd day; the same prompts repeat over time.

## 4 Base map

94,249 pairs > 71,895 cite outside pages > 13,921 with a page naming you. 16,926 cite your own page.

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, n = 94,249 brand-answer pairs

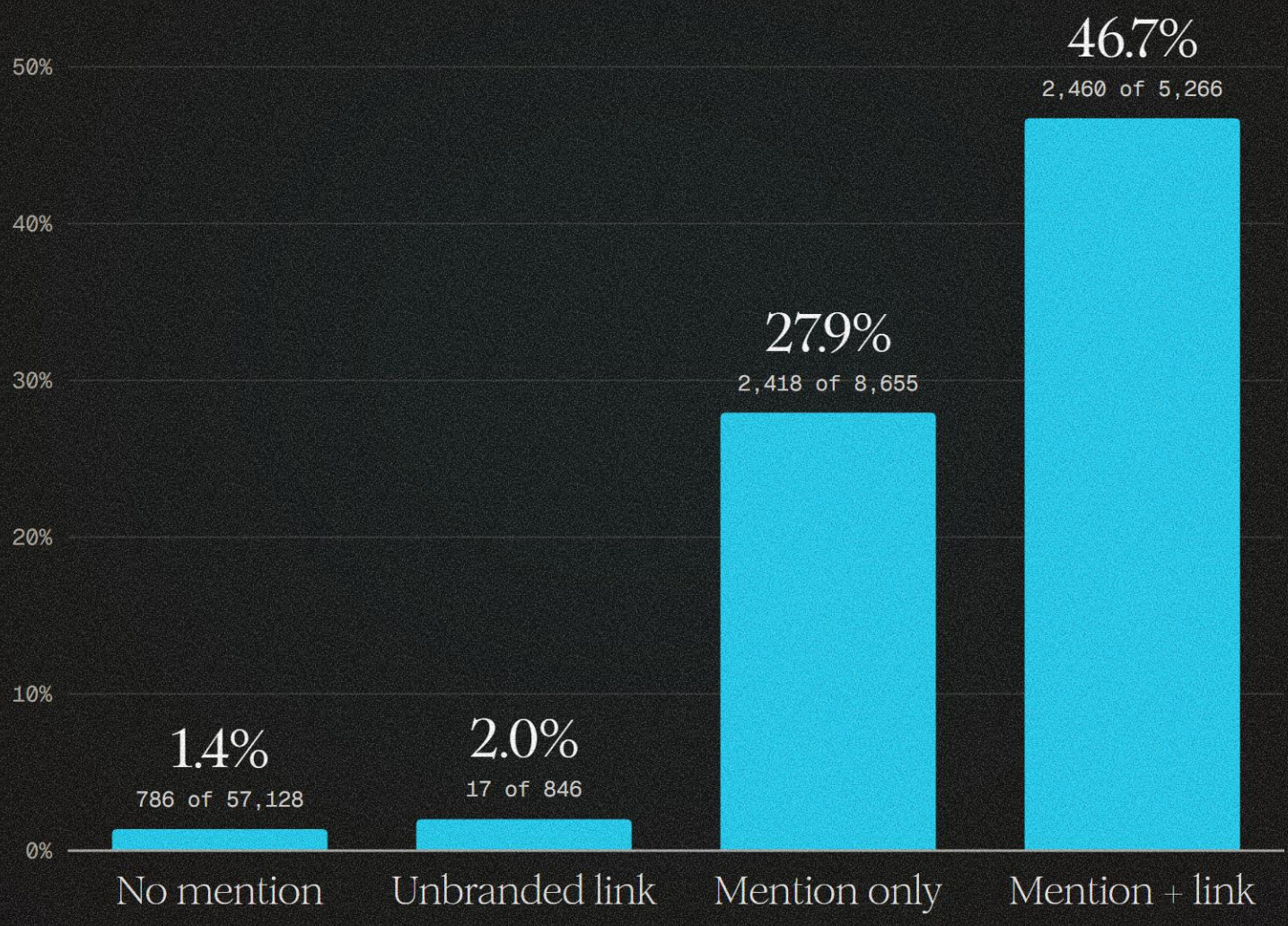


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# Brand named by AI: *no mention*, *unbranded link or mention*

% of AI answers naming the brand, by what the cited outside pages do




Same brand: mention beat unbranded link 6 of 6. Unbranded link = no mention

Base: 71,895 answers citing outside pages (own pages excluded). Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, 4 engines



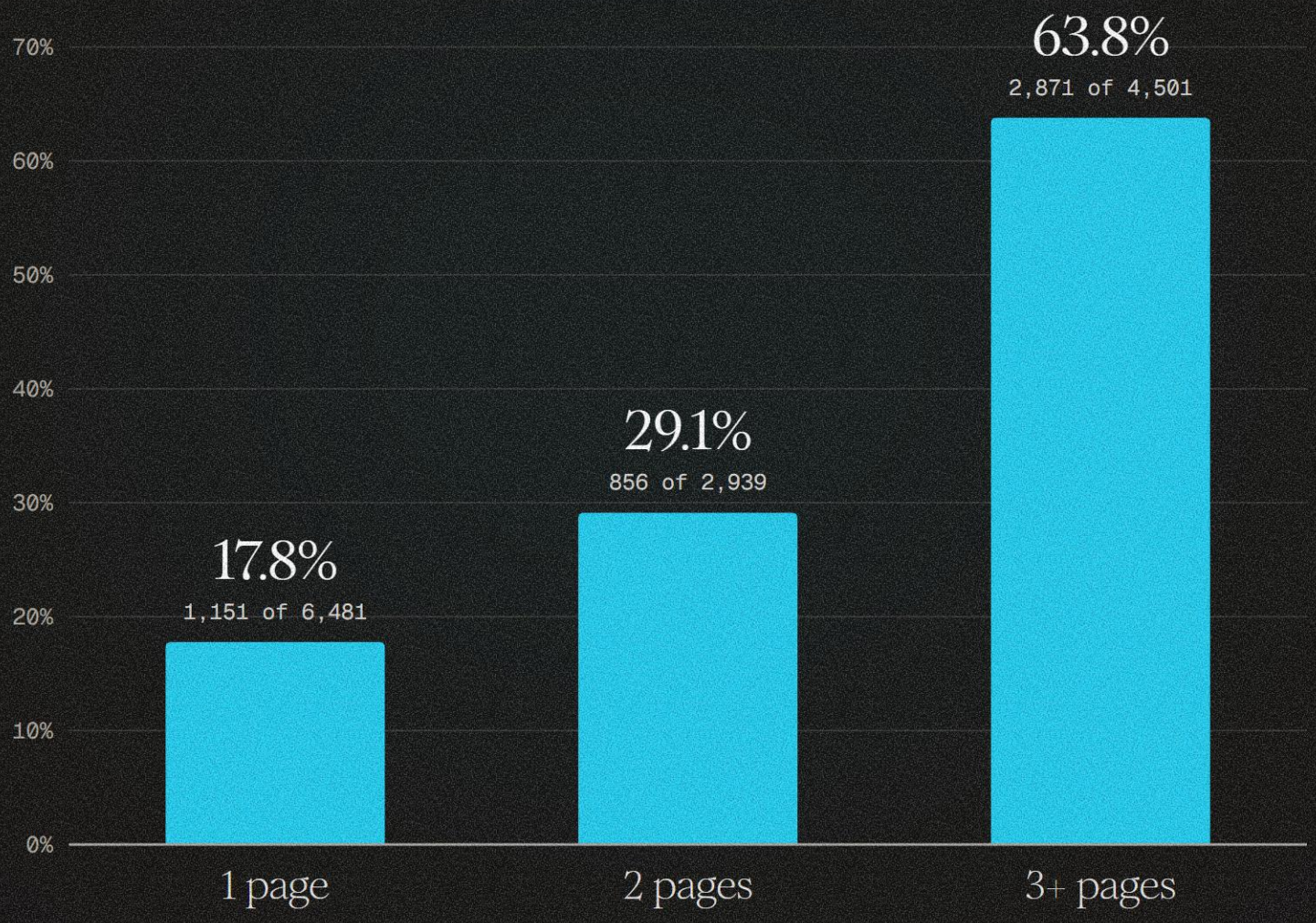
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# More pages naming you, *more AI answers name you*

% naming the brand, by how many cited outside pages mention it




Same brand: 3+ beat 1 in 15 of 15 brands. Same question: 1.8x

95% CI by brand: 1 page 10-23% · 2: 18-40% · 3+: 54-74%. Base 13,921 answers



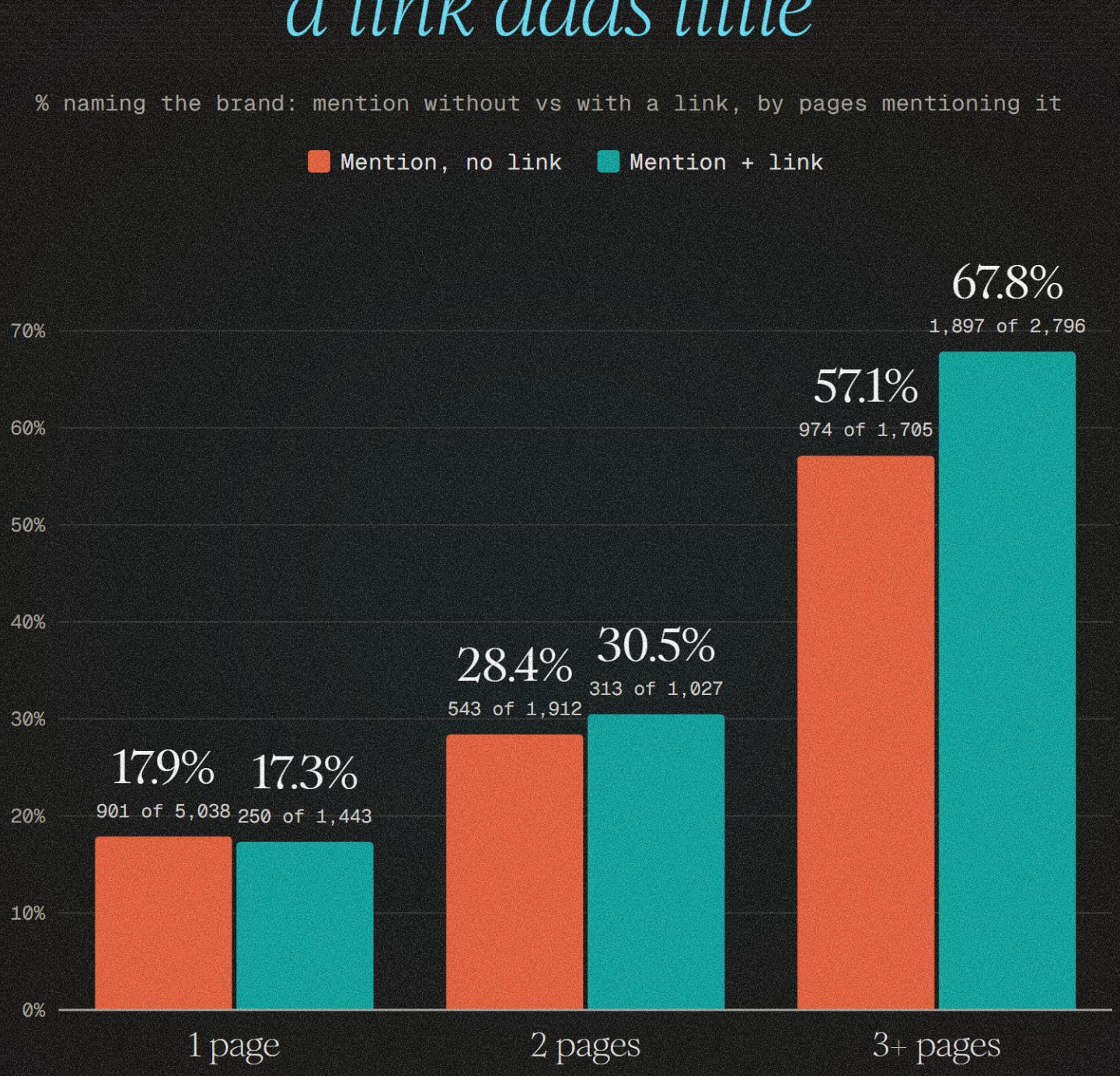
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# Same number of mentions: *a link adds little*

% naming the brand: mention without vs with a link, by pages mentioning it




1 page: 17.9% vs 17.3%. Link ahead only at 3+ (not tested within brand)

Base: 13,921 answers where a cited outside page names the brand. Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, 4 engines




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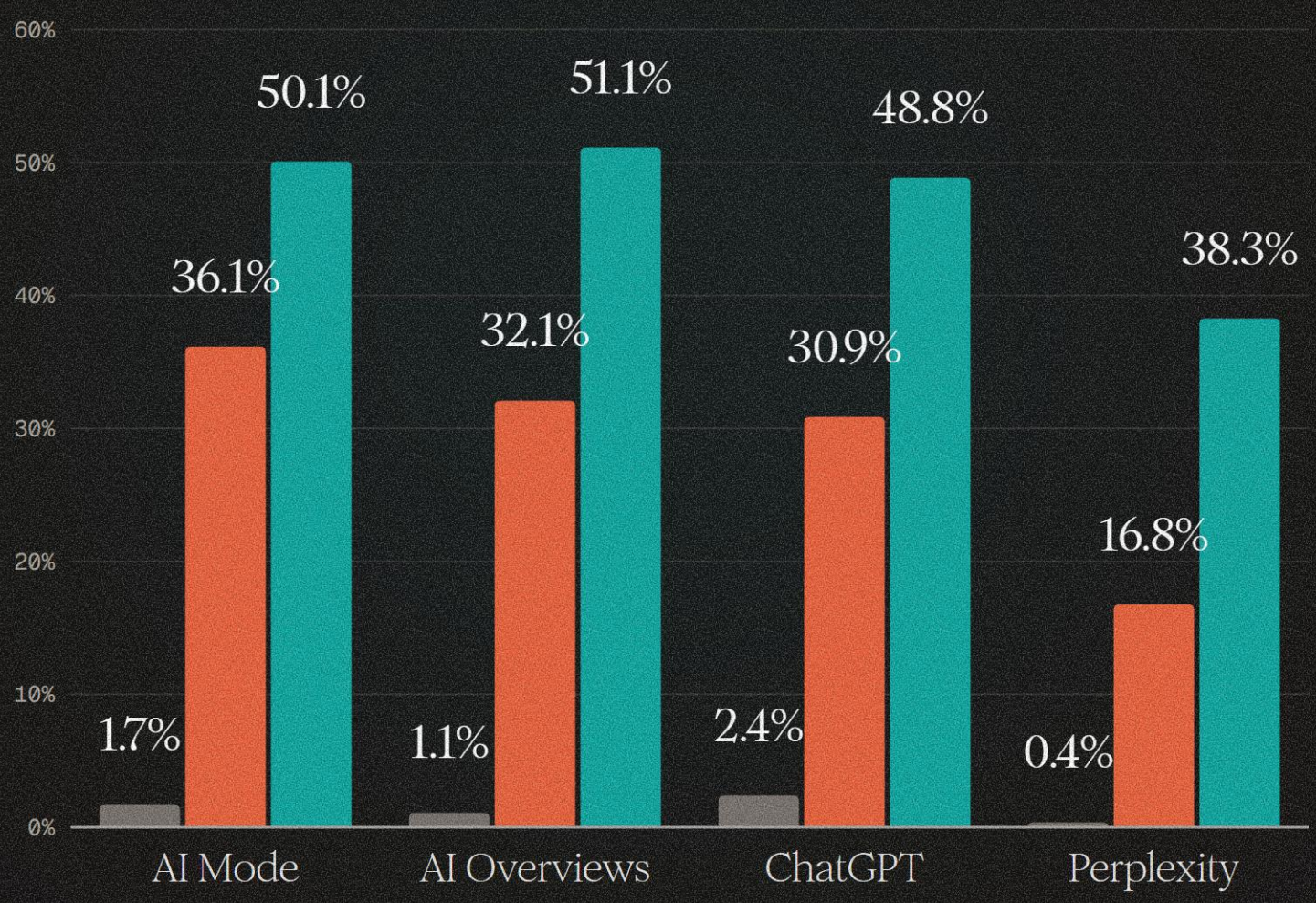
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# Brands named, per AI engine: *by what cited pages say*

% of AI answers naming the brand, per engine




Linked mentions look stronger because they show up where many pages already name the brand

Base: 71,049 answers (own-page, link-only and no-data excluded). Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, 4 engines




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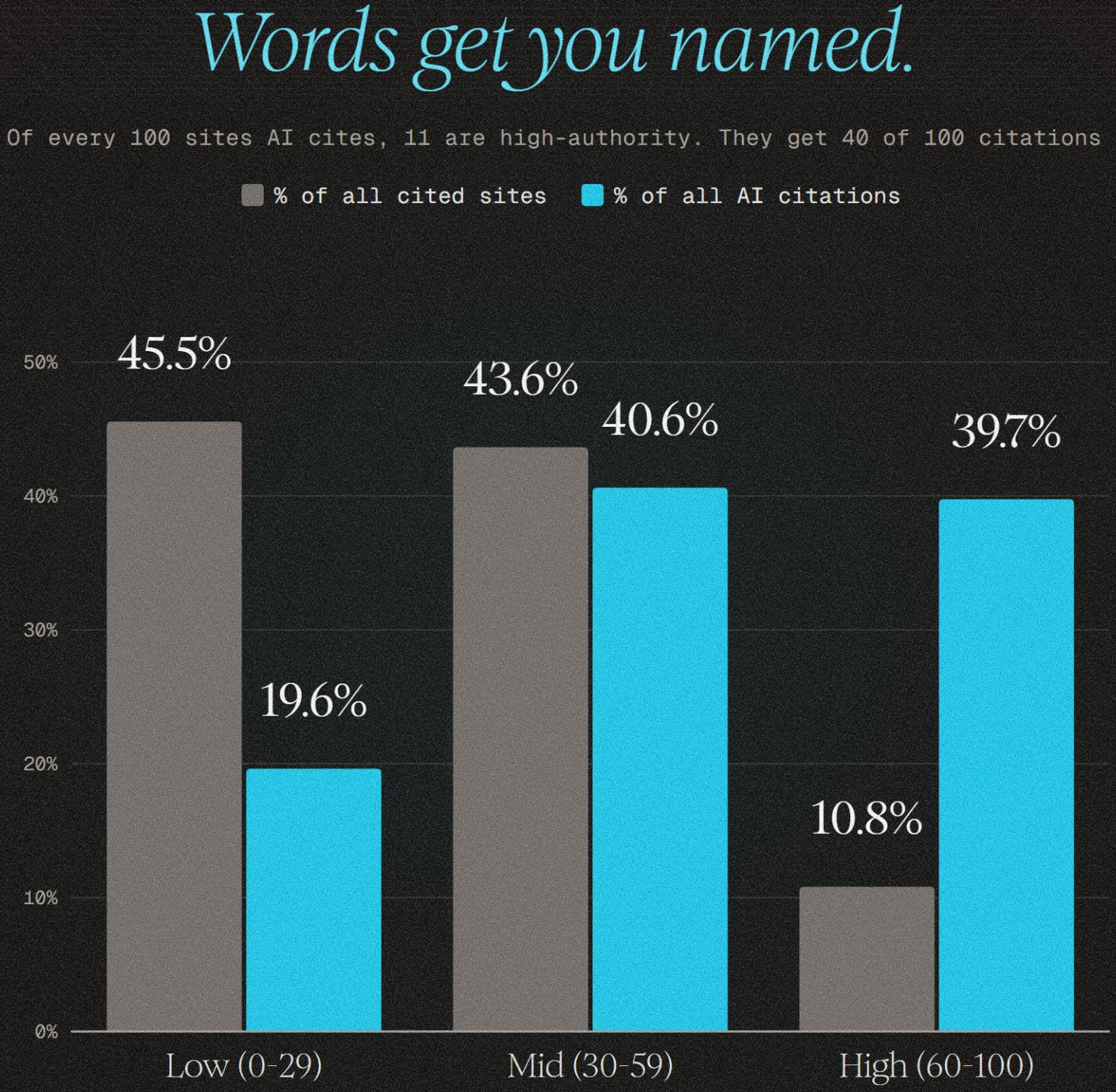
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# Authority gets you found. *Words get you named.*

Of every 100 sites AI cites, 11 are high-authority. They get 40 of 100 citations




Once cited: mentioning-page authority 1.17x (n.s.); a mention ~8x

Base: 92,440 cited sites, 10,058,762 citations, all Reach clients. DataForSEO




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# What to *do*

Each action maps to a finding in this deck

## 1 Get named on pages AI already cites

Find the outside pages AI cites for your prompts. No mention: 1.4% named; a mention: 27.9%.

## 2 Aim for 3+ of them

1 page: 17.8% named. 2: 29.1%. 3+: 63.8%. Holds in 15 of 15 brands.

## 3 Names over links

An unbranded link does as well as nothing (2.0%). Use links to add sources, not as the goal.

## 4 Put your brand in your page titles

Own pages: 32.0% vs 13.9% ghosted. Page backlinks: no detectable difference.

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, n = 94,249 brand-answer pairs



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# How many pages *name you*?

## Comment *SOURCES*

Data: Reach, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, 4 AI engines

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, n = 94,249 brand-answer pairs



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# *Methodology* & limits

Observational. Only pages AI already cites. Mostly B2B brands. Read-only, aggregate

## 1 Sample: 43 brands, 4 AI engines

Every 2nd day, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, up to 250 pairs per engine-day. Prompts repeat, so CIs resample brands.

## 2 Pages checked in Reach's snapshots

Mention = brand name in the text. Unbranded link = links to the brand's domain, no name. Snapshots may differ.

## 3 Named, and how 1.4% happens

Reach's extraction flag. With no mention, AI can still name a brand from its own knowledge or the prompt.

## 4 Limits: search answers only

Covers AI answers that use search. What the model knows from training also affects naming, and isn't measured here.

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 1-Aug 21 2026, n = 94,249 brand-answer pairs



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